



PRINCE OF PERSIA

THE TWO THRONES

POP:TTT has all the good stuff in the previous two instalments, and then some. What's not to like?

Prince Of Persia: The Two Thrones (TTT) is the last game in the Ubisoft *Prince of Persia* trilogy. It almost brings a tear to the eye knowing this is the last game, but I can think of no better way to end such a series than with a game as fun as TTT. The game, in many ways, is a synthesis of all that was good in the previous two. It returns you to the bright and fairytale-like environment we saw in *The Sands of Time*, and largely retains the combat system of *Warrior Within*. The Prince himself, who was said to have become arrogant and uncaring in *Warrior Within*, starts to return to his old noble self, while retaining some of the darkness that's come over him in the course of his past experiences.

Home Sweet Home

The beginning of TTT might seem confusing for those who did not unlock the alternative ending in WW—it starts with the Prince returning to Babylon with his new love, Kaileena, after having changed both their fates, finally looking forward to some peace and quiet. Unfortunately, as he returns, he finds that Babylon is under siege by a mysterious enemy, who captures and kills Kaileena, releasing once more the sands of time. A chain-like weapon called the Daggertail gets fused onto the Prince's arm, energised by the sands. Furthermore, he discovers that a "Dark Prince" has awoken inside him as a result of all the trials and tribulations he has faced, and his experiences while on the run from the Dahaka and on the Island of Time.

The Dark Prince isn't really all that evil, strictly speaking, as one might find after listening to the many conversations that he has with the Prince throughout the game. In

fact, he's a rather cool character. Though usually cynical and mocking, the Dark Prince also helps the Prince out here and there, providing the Prince with explanations concerning events, and suggestions on how to kill various types of enemies. The Prince also undergoes a physical transformation into the Dark Prince, and can change back only upon contact with water. The character development of TTT is very nice; the Prince experiences several moments of conflict between his two personas as you play.

As we've mentioned, the game retains the combat system of *Warrior Within*, which is a good thing. If you enjoyed brutally hacking your enemies in half, decapitating them or strangling and then gutting them with their own weapon, you shall not be let down. A new addition, however, is the stealth system. As an alternative to fighting every enemy

in a room at once, you can choose to take them out from behind or above when they're not looking. The screen flashes to indicate that a stealth kill is possible, and then you can initiate an attack sequence where you must press a button at key moments when time will slow down for a moment. If you fail to do so, the enemy will knock you away, and every enemy in the room will be alerted as well!

The system isn't terribly complicated, but attaining success requires a certain amount of concentration and care. The same system is also used in the boss battles, in an attempt to address the complaint that the boss battles in *Warrior Within* were too monotonous. The attack sequences vary depending on the kind of enemy, and you can even do quick kills on two enemies simultaneously. Stealth kills sometimes tend to become monotonous—if you repeatedly encounter the same type of enemy—but that's about the only complaint that comes to mind. I liked this addition, but luckily for those who don't, it's optional, except for the boss battles.

What would a POP game be like without the Prince's legendary acrobatics? TTT continues the tradition of presenting players with numerous acrobatic puzzles, with improvements and additions. The Prince has a few new tricks up his sleeve; he can now, for example, stick his dagger into wall-plates (among other things), thus making for extended acrobatic sequences. It's now much simpler to figure out where you have to go, thanks to the landscape camera, which will indicate your objective. Of course, the game also sports a fair share of environmental puzzles (since puzzles are an integral part of the POP series), ranging from simple ones where you have to find a lever